

Participation in licensed early childhood services

June 2025 ECE Census results¹

193,033

children attended licensed early childhood services.

72%

of children attending licensed early childhood services were enrolled at education and care services.

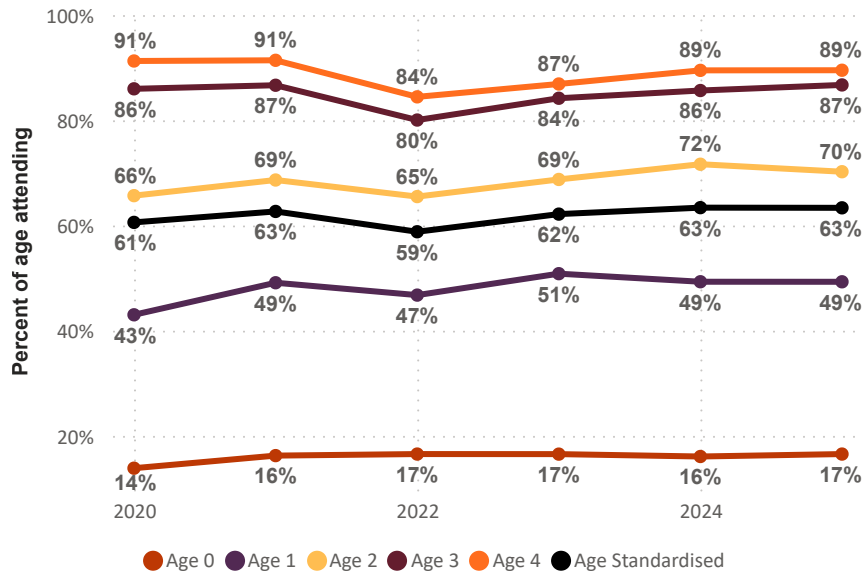
17%

of mokopuna Māori attending licensed early childhood services were enrolled in kōhanga reo.

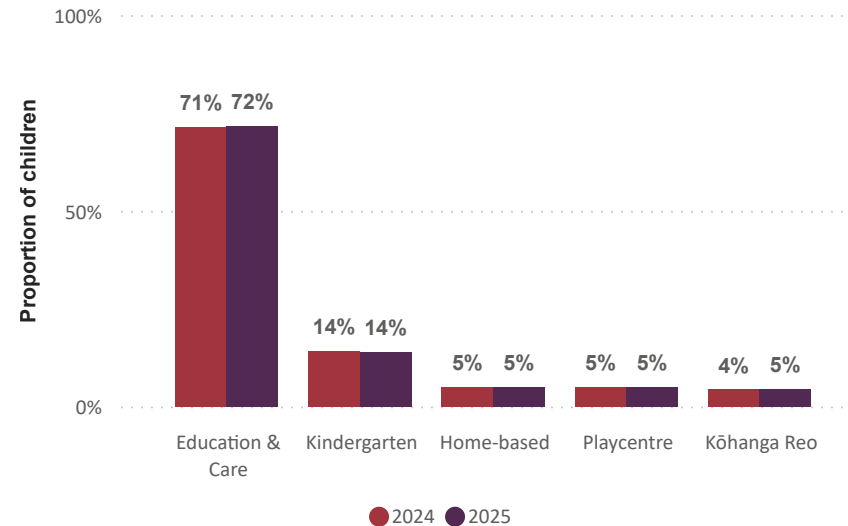
The number of children attending licensed early childhood services² decreased from 194,597 in 2024 to 193,033 in 2025 (a decrease of 1%).

- Since 2024, the number of children attending licensed early childhood services increased for the following ages: 0, 3, 4, 5 year-olds.
- In 2025, 4-year-olds had the highest rate of ECE attendance (89%).
- Since 2024, 3-year-olds have had the largest increase in the proportion attending ECE (up 1 pp³).

Percent of children attending licensed early childhood services by age



Attendance by service type

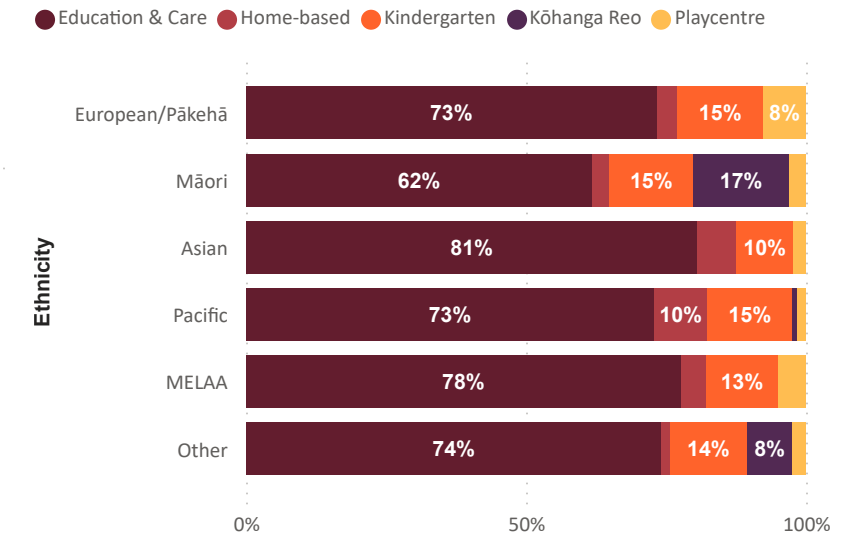


- Education and care services⁴ continued to be the most common service type attended. Since 2024, the proportion of children attending education and care services compared to other service types has increased (0.2 pp).
- Licensed home-based services have seen no change in the proportions of children participating, compared to other service types, since 2024.

For all ethnicities, education and care was the most common service type attended. This was followed by:

- Kōhanga reo (17%) for mokopuna Māori
- Kindergarten (10%) for Pacific children
- Kindergarten (10%) for European/Pākehā children
- Kindergarten (9%) for Asian children.

Participation by ethnicity and service type



¹This data is from the Ministry of Education's annual Early Childhood Education Census, held 23-29 June 2025. Further information can be found on [Education Counts](#). ²The percentage of children attending licensed early childhood services was calculated using Statistics New Zealand's Estimated Resident Population by Age and Sex (1991+) (Annual-Jun). Licensed early learning services include education and care service, licensed home-based services, kindergarten, kōhanga reo and playcentres. ³PP is short for percentage point. MELAA is short for Middle-Eastern, Latin American and African. ⁴Ngā moana reo services (puna reo, reo rua education and care, leo o fanau moana bilingual and leo o fanau moana immersion) are included in the education and care service type.